



Action plan

INTEGRATE armed forces with the Ministry of Defence

APPOINT a chief of defence staff, a single point military adviser to the Government

FAST TRACK pending military purchases. Lay down time-bound programme for acquisitions and cut it down from the present six- to eight-year timeframe.

SET UP separate Ministry for Defence Procurement staffed by permanent specialists to smoothen the acquisition process

CREATE Raksha Udyog Ratnas from

the private sector giving them the status of

defence PSUs to boost indigenous defence enterprise

BUILD more greenfield shipyards within the country to encourage local shipbuilding and help coast guard and marine police meet force levels

INDUCT satellites, UAVs and long range spy planes to improve surveillance over land and sea

PLUG existing gaps in defence air space by inducting radars

ACQUIRE capabilities like precision strikes and night fighting than merely inducting platforms

treated as an ancillary department of the Government. They are consulted, but do not form the part of decision-making.

The Indian armed forces must plan to take on potential adversaries, strong states as well as transnational non-state actors. They must follow the imperatives of precision, long-range warfare. In today's hi-tech wars, enemy forces are located and destroyed by pinpoint attacks using precision guided munitions. Unfortunately for the Indian forces, they sometimes lack even middle-level technology.

Since our armed forces can be targets of modern combat capabilities, they must be reorganised into smaller, more mobile forces. The qualifications of the soldiers and officers have to be upgraded sharply. The whole intellectual culture of the armed forces needs to change to reflect the need for integration as well as hi-tech warfare.

The armed forces should become part of the national secu-

Experts' opinions

On how India can build a stronger security mechanism

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■ Sensitise the political leadership to the nuances of national security decision making; institutionalise the defence planning process; formulate a national security strategy; ensure better civil-military integration; enhance the acquisition, dissemination of intelligence

■ Enhance military preparedness for instant execution of military operations; acquire more Aerostat radars, UAVs, AWACS and spy satellites; deploy special forces for anti-terrorist operations; hire more human intelligence assets for cross-border intelligence

rity decision making process and should be given clear politico-military directives. The army, navy and air force must be totally integrated. Modern technologies such as satellites and UAVs must be shared by the three services. The existing command and control system needs to give way to the concept of theatre commands. Flag service must be reduced to seven years for jawans. Like the navy, the other services should, too, consider training their officers to higher levels. The armed forces must be taken out of all police functions. A vibrant defence R&D base and industry must be created. India must establish a military wing of its space programme.

As India's economic and cultural footprint increases, it has to examine radically different strategies. Many of these challenges, such as terrorism, are faced by the civilised world at large, but, if India seeks a certain standing in the comity of nations, it must pull its own weight.